STORMING FORWARD

Hundreds of thousands of Germans died in the great blood-lettings of Verdun and the Somme in 1916, and in the Allied offensives of 1917. As the war went on, a gulf opened up in the German ranks between battle-hardened troops who had survived this carnage and the ageing reservists or fresh young conscripts who were required to make up the numbers at the front. The best soldiers were grouped into elite formations of "stormtroopers" and used to spearhead counterattacks and offensives. The stormtrooper concept was traceable to an assault unit created in March 1915 by Captain Willy Rohr of the Prussian Guards Rifles. Through 1916 and 1917 storm battalions became common, along with smaller stormtrooper detachments in standard infantry regiments. They were created either by the conversion of units of riflemen (Jäger) or by hand-picking the best soldiers from conventional infantry. Stormtroopers received intensive training and they were encouraged to regard themselves as the "princes of the trenches". A storm battalion might consist of three or four infantry companies armed with rifles and hand grenades, a machine-gun company, a trench mortar company, a battery of light infantry guns, and a flamethrower section. They were expected to operate on their own initiative, punching holes through the enemy's trench systems without stopping. The concept of the stormtrooper represented a bold attempt to exploit the fighting skills of superbly trained infantry in a war paralysed by the brute attritional impact of massed firepower. Its drawback was that standard infantry units were stripped of their best men, who were then thrown into the forefront of every costly counterattack or offensive. Inevitably, the stormtroopers took heavy casualties, so that German losses were concentrated among their finest, most experienced soldiers.



Enlightened warfare
Magnesium flares, known as star shells, were fired into the air by a flare pistol to send prearranged signals. Some shells had parachutes that slowed their descent. Star shells were also used to illuminate No Man's Land and reveal enemy activity.



Trench axe
Although used primarily as a general purpose tool in the trenches, the axe was useful for close-quarters fighting during trench-raiding missions.

KAISERSCHLACHT

The acid test of the effectiveness of stormtroopers came with the Kaiserschlacht offensive of March 1918. This was a desperate gamble by the German High Command, who threw the resources released by victory over Russia on the Eastern Front into a massive offensive in the West, hoping to win the war before American troops were ready to fight. On 21 March the full force of the German onslaught fell upon the British Third and Fifth Armies. After being subjected to a ferocious

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>
> **STEFAN WESTMANN**, 29TH DIVISION GERMAN ARMY



Over the top
German stormtroopers laden with equipment advance over open but broken ground during the spring offensive of 1918. The enemy know of their approach because of a preliminary barrage.